QA | LAB 3

Section 508 Testing Past the Checker

The checker said pass. Keyboard only found four failures. Accessibility testing at three employers.

What this proves: Section 508 testing that protects real users and gives developers fixes they can make the same day.

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Recreated from real Section 508 work at three employers. No employer data. No DHS Trusted Tester Certification is claimed.

The problem

An application passed its automated accessibility checker and still could not be used with a keyboard. A screen reader user hit an error they never received, because the error was only a red border.

How I built it

1. Ran the automated checker first and recorded it as the baseline, not the verdict.
2. Unplugged the mouse for the full workflow: reached every control by keyboard and tracked visible focus at each step.
3. Tested errors properly: every error in text, naming the field, reachable by a screen reader, never color alone.
4. Tested labels and alt text by meaning, not presence. Alt text that is a file name describes nothing.
5. Tested focus and reading order against the visual task order, including where focus lands after an error.
6. Wrote findings with the fix attached: component, criterion in plain language, keyboard steps, expected vs actual.

Validation, expected vs actual

Check	Checker said	Keyboard pass found
Alt text	Pass, present	Fail on meaning, alt was a file name
Focus visible	Not checked	Fail, focus lost after an error
Error in text form	Not checked	Fail, color only error
Full task by keyboard	Not checked	Blocked at step 4, passed after fix

Every serious finding in this lab was invisible to the checker. That is not an argument against checkers. It is the reason the keyboard pass exists.

The finding

Compliance is the floor. A person finishing their task is the standard. Most accessibility fixes are small once found. Finding them requires doing the task the way the user does it, under the constraints the user actually has, and that is testing work, not tool work.

Deliverables in this lab

- Accessibility checklist: keyboard, focus, errors, labels, order
- Findings report with fix suggestion per item
- Before and after retest log

Skills shown: Section 508, accessibility testing, WCAG concepts, testing, QA, healthcare IT, banking, Jira, ALM Quality Center